



Exploratory Testing

The Art of Discovery

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🚀 **TL;DR**

Scripted Testing confirms what we already know (Checking the map).

Exploratory Testing discovers what we *don't* know (Going off-road).

It is simultaneous learning, test design, and execution.

🧠 **The Core Definition**

Many people think Exploratory Testing is just clicking around randomly. **It is not.**

That is called "Monkey Testing."

Exploratory Testing is structured.

- **Simultaneous:** We design the test in our head and execute it at the same time.
 - **Time-Boxed:** We set a timer (e.g., "I will spend 30 minutes on this feature").
 - **Charter-Based:** We have a specific mission (e.g., "Explore the checkout process specifically for payment failures").
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The Tourist Analogy

Scripted Testing (The Tourist with a Guidebook):

You visit Paris. You go to the Eiffel Tower, then the Louvre, then the Cafe. You follow the list exactly.

Result: You see exactly what you expected to see.

Exploratory Testing (The Backpacker):

You visit Paris. You see an interesting alleyway and decide to walk down it. You find a hidden bakery. You ask the baker for a recommendation.

Result: You find things that were not in the guidebook.

Exploratory vs. Ad-Hoc (The Confusion)

Ad-Hoc Testing (The Improvisation)

- **Plan:** None. You test on the fly.
- **Knowledge: High.** You know the app, but you are just trying things out without a script.
- **Goal:** A quick check or "poking around" to see if a specific area works.

Exploratory Testing (The Investigation)

- **Plan:** Yes. It uses a "**Charter**" (A specific mission).
 - **Knowledge: High.** You are learning and designing tests simultaneously.
 - **Goal:** To deeply understand behavior and find logical bugs.
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💡 Real World Example: The Shopping Cart

The Charter: "Explore the Shopping Cart behavior when the internet connection is unstable."

The Session (30 Minutes):

1. I add an item.
2. I turn off my WiFi.
3. I click "Checkout".
4. *Observation:* The loading spinner spins forever.
5. I turn WiFi back on.
6. *Observation:* The spinner is still spinning. The app is stuck.

Conclusion:

I didn't have a test case for "Turn off WiFi," but my curiosity led me to a critical bug. I logged it, and now we will write a script for it next time.

🧠 Why This Matters

Scripts are great for **Regression** (checking old features).

Exploratory is essential for **New Features**.

You cannot write a script for a bug you don't know exists yet. Exploratory testing helps you find the "Unknown Unknowns."